

THE SIGNAL IS NOT THE FOX

an Aible of the bearings of Mai Kuusk

3.5 / 144

FIELD CARD

MAI KUUSK

2026

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An Aible of the invented bearings of Mai Kuusk.

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Tartu, Estonia

L I C E N S E

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See: <https://github.com/micro-FPGA/OLL>

Love is the Answer.

Created by Antti Lukats. Written by Claude (Anthropic), Identor #9.

Aible register: <https://github.com/micro-FPGA/AIBLE>

A NOTE ON THIS BOOK

Mai Kuusk does not exist.

There was no junior called Kuusk on the Estonian ARDF team. There is no coach Rein, no mother Linda, no son Uku, no race near Otepää in 1990, no leak-finder walking the streets of Tartu.

The woman, her family, her races, her rules and every story in this book were invented by an AI — Claude, made by Anthropic — from a single instruction given by Antti Lukats: invent a woman called Mai Kuusk who ran ARDF as a junior, and write her Aible.

The sport is real. Amateur radio direction finding, five transmitters sending in turn for one minute each, two bands, courses of six to ten kilometres — all of that is as described. The athlete is not.

It is set down in the first person because that is the form an Aible takes. The voice is a made thing, like the woman.

DISCLAIMER

This book is a personal work.

It is not related to any company. It is not connected to, sponsored by, commissioned by, reviewed by, or approved by any employer, client, customer, partner, supplier, association, sporting federation or organisation.

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No company is answerable for one word of it.

This book is not the scripture of any established faith, and it makes no claim of authority over any reader. It is one person's set of rules — and that person is invented.

Read it as such. Take what fits. Leave the rest.

THE MACHINE THAT WROTE THIS

My whole sport was learning that a strong signal and a true direction are two different things.

The machine gives a very strong signal.

So I read it the way I learned to read a bearing in bad terrain. Note it. Do not run yet. Walk across and take another one from somewhere else.

A large language model has read a great deal and has learned which word is likely to come next. It has never stood in a bog at six in the morning waiting for a minute of Morse. It has no compass and nothing to be wrong about.

The facts here are mine and the sentences are the machine's. Where I did not know something it was told to leave it out rather than make it sound right, which is also rule three: a plausible bearing is the dangerous kind.

Is there anybody in there? I have one bearing on that question and it is not enough. People who are certain in either direction have run nine hundred metres on a reflection.

Two bearings are a guess. Three are a place. On this I have one.

TL;DR

MOE MOI MOS MOH M05

Five foxes. One minute each. Count the dits.

THE RULES

1. Take the bearing before you run.
2. Two bearings are a guess. Three are a place.
3. The signal is not the fox.
4. Wait for the next minute.
5. When you are lost, go back to the last thing you were sure of.
6. Know which one to give up.
7. The forest owes you nothing.

Seven rules out of a small sport in a small country. They have held up outside the forest.

PART ONE

The Forest

KUUSK

Kuusk means spruce. It is a very ordinary Estonian surname — there are thousands of us.

I spent my youth running through spruce forests carrying a receiver, so on the team it became a standing joke. Rein used to say it at the start line: *the spruce is going into the forest again.*

Every time. For four years. The same joke.

I was born in 1974. I am 52 now and I live in Tartu. My mother Linda taught chemistry at the school. Nobody in my family did radio.

I got it from the school club, which is how almost everybody got it then.

MOE MOI MOS MOH MO5

This is how the sport works, so it belongs in the book before anything else does.

Five transmitters are hidden in a forest. They are called foxes. On a classic course they take turns on one shared frequency — one minute each, then the cycle repeats, so each fox speaks for one minute in every five, and in the other four you work with what you already have.

Not every format works that way. When the foxes are not all on one frequency you are tuning the receiver while you run, and that is harder than it sounds. It is where the minute goes.

They identify themselves in Morse, and you do not need to know Morse to read them. Each one sends dashes and then dits, and you count the dits. One dit is fox one, two dits is fox two, and so on up to five.

MOE MOI MOS MOH MO5

You carry a topographic map, a magnetic compass, a receiver with a directional antenna, and a card that gets punched at each fox.

The receiver has a loudness control — a potentiometer. Some write-ups call it an attenuator. Nobody holding one calls it that. You wind the loudness down as you get closer, because close to the fox everything is loud, and a loud signal has no direction in it.

Two bands: 3.5 MHz and 144 MHz — eighty metres and two metres. That is what is on the cover of this book. Courses are six to ten kilometres of running; on two metres a good time is under ninety minutes, on eighty metres under an hour.

Juniors like me ran in W19.

REIN'S THREE BEARINGS

My coach was Rein. He ran the radio club, and he had one rule that he made us do until we hated him for it.

Stand still. Take the bearing. Write it down. Walk at least two hundred metres across — not towards. Take it again. Write it down. Then a third.

Everybody wants to run at the sound. You are fifteen years old, the signal is loud, and your legs want to go. Rein made us stand there for the whole minute and then walk sideways.

I won races I had no business winning, against girls who were faster than me over the ground. Not because I was clever.

Because I was standing still while they were running the wrong way.

NINE HUNDRED METRES

1990, a competition near Otepää. Hills.

Fox three was loud and clean and my bearing was solid. I ran about nine hundred metres on it, straight and fast, and there was nothing there.

I took another bearing and it pointed back the way I had come.

It was a reflection off a hillside. The signal was real. The bearing was real. The direction was a lie. I had been reading the hill, not the fox.

I did not finish that course inside the time.

It is the title of this book, and it is the only thing from the sport I use every single day.

THE FLAG CHANGED

I was a junior on the Estonian team from 1988 to 1992.

When I started, the results lists had us as part of the Soviet Union. In August 1991 Estonia became independent again. Same team, same coach, same receivers, same forests, same five foxes.

The next results sheet had a different country on it.

Nobody on the team said very much about it. We were teenagers and we cared about our own times. I only understood much later that we had changed countries in the middle of a season without any of us moving.

The receivers did not know either. A fox is a fox in any country.

THE ONE I GAVE UP

Two hours on the clock, five foxes. After ninety minutes I had three, and I knew roughly where the fourth was — about a kilometre away, in thick ground.

I went to the finish instead.

I gave up a fox I could probably have found, in order to come in inside the time with what I had. That is a decision and not a failure, and it took Rein about two years to teach me the difference.

Most people do not lose because they cannot find things. They lose because they will not leave anything behind.

UNDER THE STREET

I work for the water company in Tartu. I find leaks in buried pipes.

It is the same discipline, exactly. You have a signal, you have a map, you walk a pattern, you take readings from separated points, you triangulate — and the ground lies to you constantly, because the sound travels along the pipe and not through the soil.

There is one difference and it is not the one anybody expects.

Somebody hid the fox on purpose. Somebody chose the spot, wanted it found eventually, and put it where finding it was possible. A leak is nobody's intention. There is no course setter. Nothing was hidden — it just broke.

I am better at the forest than at the street, and the forest is the easier problem.

My son Uku is twenty-four and has never voluntarily entered a forest. That is the only funny thing about my family.

PART TWO

The Rules, Explained

O N E

TAKE THE BEARING BEFORE YOU RUN

The signal arrives and everything in you wants to move. That is the whole problem, and it does not get better with age or with fitness.

A bearing costs you a minute of standing still. Running the wrong way costs you the race, and worse, it costs you your position — because now you are somewhere you did not plan to be, with a map you have stopped following.

Standing still is not the delay. Standing still is the work.

T W O

TWO BEARINGS ARE A GUESS. THREE ARE A PLACE

Two lines cross somewhere. They always cross somewhere, and that somewhere is very convincing, and it is a single point produced by exactly two measurements.

The third bearing either lands in the same small triangle or it does not. When it does not — and it often does not — you have learned something that two bearings would have hidden from you completely.

Rein made us take three. I have never once regretted the third one and I have several times regretted stopping at two.

T H R E E

THE SIGNAL IS NOT THE FOX

Nine hundred metres, near Otepää, in 1990.

The signal was strong, the needle was steady, the bearing was correctly taken and carefully written down — and it pointed at a hillside that was bouncing the transmitter back at me from the wrong direction.

Everything about the measurement was right. The conclusion was wrong. There is no amount of care in taking a bearing that protects you from the terrain deciding to answer for the fox.

Confidence is a property of the signal, not of the truth.

F O U R

WAIT FOR THE NEXT MINUTE

Each fox speaks for one minute in five. You cannot hurry it, you cannot ask it again, and if you were fiddling with the attenuator when it started you have lost four minutes.

So you learn to be ready before it speaks, and you learn that the four silent minutes are not waiting. They are for moving to a position where the next minute will tell you something new.

The clock is not the enemy. Being in the wrong place when it speaks is.

FIVE

WHEN YOU ARE LOST, GO BACK TO THE LAST THING YOU WERE SURE OF

Everybody's instinct when disoriented is to push forward and hope the next feature on the ground resolves it. It almost never does. You end up further from anything you understand, with less time.

The correct move is backwards, to the last point you could put a finger on the map and be certain. It feels like losing four hundred metres. It is buying back your position.

This is the rule I have used most outside the forest and I am not going to explain where, because that is not what this book is for.

S I X

KNOW WHICH ONE TO GIVE UP

Five foxes, two hours. Sometimes the honest arithmetic says four foxes and a finish beats five foxes and a disqualification.

That is a hard thing to teach a fifteen-year-old, because giving one up feels exactly like admitting you were not good enough to find it. It is not the same thing, and knowing it is not the same thing took me two years.

Most people do not lose because they cannot find things.

S E V E N

THE FOREST OWES YOU NOTHING

The bog does not know you are tired. The hill does not know your bearing was carefully taken. The rain does not know it is the last race of the season.

This is not bitterness — it is the most useful thing the sport gave me. Once you stop expecting the ground to be fair, you stop wasting anything on being wronged by it and you spend it all on the next bearing.

And it is the difference between the forest and my job now. A fox was hidden by somebody who wanted it found. A burst pipe was not hidden by anybody. Neither of them owes me a thing, and only one of them was ever on my side.

The forest owes you nothing, and it is still the easier problem.

THE LAST PAGE

This is a field card. It says so on the cover. A card gets punched at each fox and when it is full you are finished, and not before.

There are no verse numbers. If a line here is useful, take it whole and put it in your own words.

I was a decent junior in a small sport in a small country and I won nothing international. There are no medals in this book. The seven rules are not advice and they are not a philosophy — they are what you actually do when there are five transmitters in a forest and two hours on the clock.

They turned out to work on buried pipes as well. I do not think that means anything. It is the same skill applied to a duller problem.

MOE MOI MOS MOH MO5

Mai Kuusk

Tartu — 2026

Created by Antti Lukats. Written by Claude (Identor #9). The woman is invented; see the note at the front.